



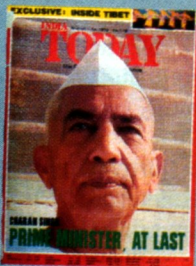
baron B. Sriramulu as a minister in the 34-member cabinet that was to be sworn on November 21. Taking his name before any member of the Gowda family is akin to showing a red flag to a bull. And there is a reason. Last September, during the campaign for the urban local body polls, Sriramulu had alleged that JD(S) workers at the behest of the then chief minister Kumaraswamy had fired at him. He had even filed an FIR alleging that Kumaraswamy had attempted to kill him. Earlier, he had launched a campaign alleging that Gowda and family were linked to a Rs 150 crore mining scam. The matter is before the courts now. No wonder then that father and son, who seemed to be drifting away, suddenly closed ranks and refused to budge on Sriramulu's inclusion in the cabinet.

The mayhem of the last few days in Bangalore can be traced back to Gowda's political career, a long innings which he has shared with several partners, each of which ended in mutual accusations of betrayal. Congress leader D.K. Shivakumar, who like Gowda belongs to the Vokkaliga community has stood against the wiles of Gowda and his family for years, even defeating his son Kumaraswamy once in the Assembly election from Sathanur constituency. He recalls how Gowda is obsessed with power and pelf for himself and his family. "He does not like any other member from the second largest caste group—Vokkaligas—to emerge as leaders. It has to be either

PRAYER UNHEEDED: Yeddyurappa (left) with Kumaraswamy

From INDIA TODAY issue dated August 1-15, 1979

ROCK BOTTOM



"The ugly politicians of today are faceless freaks: born of a reckless greed to grab power, fed on unscrupulous ambition to retain it, their ultimate lust is geared to self-preservation. Nothing else exits in the minds of the khadi-clad effigies that stalk the political ruins of

Delhi these days. Like bands of itinerant eunuchs roaming the streets to celebrate the curse of their social ostracism, Indian politicians too have come to represent the rock bottom of Indian society. Faithless, fickle and fragmented in their chronic quest for

power, they have reduced the ethics of the power game to a squalid striptease. Like chanting hijras, who lift their skirts at every corner to reveal their deformed genitalia, India's national leaders have come out in the open to parade their savage sins."